



USA: Southwest

THE SOUTHWEST is an area of great contrasts. Much of Oklahoma and Texas consists of flat, rolling grasslands and huge farms, while both Arizona and New Mexico are hot, arid, and mountainous, with vast canyons and river valleys carving their way through the land. Since the discovery of oil in 1901, Texas has become the country's top oil producer with Houston as the center of the billion-dollar industry. Tourism is also important to the Southwest, as visitors flock to see the Grand Canyon, the Painted Desert, and other natural wonders. Buildings here reflect the mix of Latino, American Indian, European American, and modern American cultures.



DESERT LIFE
The saguaro cactus can reach up to 50 ft (15 m) tall, grow as many as 40 branches, and live for 200 years. Cacti, yucca, and other plants have all adapted to the hot, dry desert conditions found in the Southwest. So, too, have many animals, including the deadly rattlesnake.

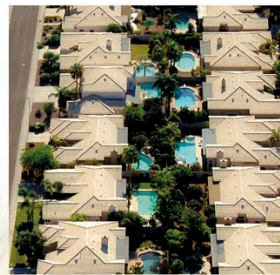
Saguaro cacti in the Sonoran Desert



0 km 50 100 150 200
0 miles 50 100 150 200

THE GRAND CANYON

The Grand Canyon in northern Arizona is one of the natural wonders of the world. This incredibly deep gorge was slowly cut out of the rock, beginning 6 million years ago, by the Colorado River. People can hike around its edge or venture down into the canyon to camp for the night.



Suburbs of Phoenix, Arizona

HOT PLACE TO LIVE

The climate across much of the Southwest is hot and dry, with summer temperatures often reaching 100°F (38°C). Although water can be scarce, many people have a swimming pool in their backyard so they can cool off.



AMERICAN-INDIAN CULTURES

American Indians, including Navajo, Hopi, and Apache, used to live across the Southwest but are now concentrated in reservations set up by the US government. The largest of these is in Arizona and New Mexico, and is home to the Navajo people. The Navajo farm the land and produce crafts, like the woven blanket wrapped around these Navajo children.



Kachina doll made by the Hopi

